

THE COMPOUND EFFECT

BRAND & DESIGN SYSTEM

One system for the franchise. **The Compound Effect** (2010) and **The Compound Effect in Business** (April 2027) are not two brands. They are one brand printed on opposite grounds, and almost everything in this document follows from that.

V1.0 · SEPTEMBER 2026 · GOVERNS THECOMPOUNDEFFECT.COM AND EVERY COMPOUND EFFECT WEB PROPERTY

01 · PACKAGE CONTENTS

WHAT SHIPS, AND WHAT IT IS FOR.

This document exists in two forms and they are kept in sync. The live page is the working reference. The package is the portable copy: self-contained HTML that opens anywhere with no network, a PDF for print and email, and the real source files a vendor or contractor will ask for.

brand-guide.html

This document, self-contained. CSS and fonts inlined, opens with no network.

brand-guide.pdf

Print and share version.

fonts/

The two licensed faces, self-hosted woff2. See section 08 for the licence position.

logos/dh/

Darren Hardy parent marks. Author identity, used in the byline position and the footer.

logos/tce/

The Compound Effect franchise lockup, light and dark.

logos/tceb/

The in-Business lockup, light and dark.

covers/

Both jackets at full resolution. These are the only product imagery the brand owns.

tceb.css

The live stylesheet the token block in section 16 is drawn from.

Keep them in sync. The live page links the real `tceb.css`, so it cannot drift from production. The package inlines a snapshot. When the stylesheet changes in a way that matters, the package is rebuilt, not hand-edited.

The 2010 jacket is red and black on white. The 2027 jacket is white and red on black. Measured side by side, the two reds sit within a few points of each other. The books were never two identities. They are an inversion of one.

THE COMPOUND EFFECT

THE COMPOUND EFFECT

ground #FFFFFF

red #E02726

ink #241F21 warm near-black

2010. Red on white, with a black band carrying the author. Light is the ground and the ink is the object.

THE COMPOUND EFFECT IN BUSINESS

IN BUSINESS

ground #000000

red #E1132E / #FF0047

ink #FFFFFF

2027. White on black, with white bands carrying the author. Dark is the ground and the light is the object.

The rule that falls out of it. A white book needs a dark ground to exist against. A black book needs a light one. So **TCE artwork goes on dark, TCEB artwork goes on light**, and any page showing both has to give each its own field rather than splitting the difference.

Inversion is not a palette swap. When a treatment moves between the two grounds, invert the physics, not the colours. A glow becomes a shadow. A vignette that lightens becomes one that darkens. An object that separates by emitting becomes one that separates by casting. Swapping hex values alone produces the effect that looks correct in a spec and wrong on a screen.

03 · IDENTITY

THREE LAYERS, IN THIS ORDER.

The author, the franchise, the book. Every page carries at least the first two, and they are never given equal weight in the same view.

1 · DARREN HARDY

The author mark. This is his brand before it is a book brand, and the franchise sits under it. Used in the byline position on a jacket, and in the footer on the web. It is never the primary mark on a book page and never competes with the title lockup.

Set in Franklin Gothic. His name is the one place that face appears. Using it anywhere else spends the only thing that makes the byline distinct.

2 · THE COMPOUND EFFECT

The franchise lockup: **THE / COMPOUND / EFFECT** stacked in the display face, with a red rule beneath. This is the parent form and it is identical on both books.

It carries the equity of two million copies. It is the constant, and the reason the second book is recognised at all.

3 · THE TAIL

Each book extends the parent lockup rather than replacing it. The 2010 book adds nothing. The 2027 book adds **IN BUSINESS**, set smaller than EFFECT, in red, on its own line. A future title would take the same position at the same relative size.

No The tail set at the same size as EFFECT. It is a qualifier, not a third word of the title.

No The franchise lockup and the DH mark at matching weight in one view. One leads.

No Franklin Gothic anywhere except his name.

No The red rule omitted. It is part of the lockup, not decoration around it.

Yes Lockup centred, its own clear space of at least the cap-height of COMPOUND on all four sides.

OPEN · NEEDS DH

The lockup is currently type set in the display face rather than a drawn mark. For a four-site property that is worth revisiting: a drawn wordmark survives at small sizes, in one colour, and on merchandise in a way that set type does not. Flagged rather than assumed.

04 · THE GROUNDS

TWO GROUNDS. NOTHING BETWEEN THEM.

The jacket does not use a tinted paper, a cream, or a warm grey. It is pure white against pure black, and the hardness of that edge is the identity.

WHITE

#FFFFFF

Flaps, back panel, the bands that frame the cover. Where the argument is made and the reading happens.

BLACK

#000000

The cover itself. Where the title lives, and the only ground gold

is permitted on.

This corrects the earlier proposal. A warm paper at #fbfaf8 and a mist grey at #dcd9d5 were drafted before the jacket was available. They soften a system that is meant to be hard, and they cost contrast: the red measures **4.64:1** on warm paper, which fails body text, and **4.85:1** on pure white, which passes. The jacket is both more elegant and more accessible.

05 · THE ACCENT

ONE RED. ONCE.

On the jacket the red appears on a single phrase per surface. **IN BUSINESS** on the cover. One sentence on the flap. One word in the URL. That discipline is the reason it lands.

Red

#E1132E

The accent on white. Headlines, one emphasis, and button fills with white type.

4.85:1 on white · passes

Red bright

#FF0047

The same role on black. Type only. Never a button fill: white on it is 3.93.

5.34:1 on black · passes



Gold

#D4A017

Founding tiers only, and only on dark. Gold fills carry black type, never white.

8.84:1 on black · 2.38 on white

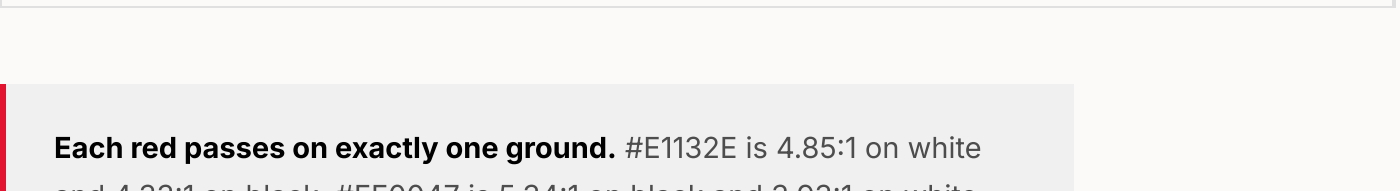


Gold lux

#CAA76A

The softer register, for when the tier should read premium rather than loud.

9.25:1 on black · 2.27 on white



Each red passes on exactly one ground. #E1132E is 4.85:1 on white and 4.33:1 on black. #FF0047 is 5.34:1 on black and 3.93:1 on white. So they are not interchangeable and neither is a "lighter version" of the other: white surfaces take #E1132E, black surfaces take #FF0047, and swapping them fails contrast in both directions.

No Red on red. Red headline above a red button is two shouts, not one.

No Gold anywhere a light ground is in play. #D4A017 is 2.38:1 on white.

No Gold type set beside red type at the same size. They are only 1.65:1 apart in luminance, so they vibrate. Separate them by size, weight or space.

No A second accent hue. There is not one, and adding one breaks the jacket.

Yes Long stretches with no colour at all. That is what makes the red work.

06 · THE NEUTRALS

GREYS ARE **TYPE TIERS**, NOT GROUNDS.

White, light grey and silver belong in this system. They earn their place as levels of type and as rules, which is how the jacket uses them. They are not additional backgrounds.

#000000 Display, on white	#262626 Body, on white	#4D4D4D 8.45 · secondary
#6E6E6E 5.10 · fine print	#B3B3B3 10.02 on black	#E0E0E0 Rules and borders
#F0F0F0		

Where silver is allowed to be a surface. One case only: a flat field behind a callout or a spec table, at #F0F0F0 or lighter. Anything darker becomes a third ground, and a third ground is what made the previous draft read as a hodge-podge.

— 07 · THE FACES

CONFIRMED FROM THE JACKET.

Two of the three are now settled by DH. The title is **Bebas Neue Pro**. His name is **Franklin Gothic**. Nothing here is an approximation of the cover any more.

DISPLAY · THE TITLE

BEBAS NEUE

Headlines, eyebrows, moneylines, tier names, any standalone number. Always uppercase, which is free because the face has no lowercase.

Jacket sets **Bebas Neue Pro** (commercial, Fontfabric). Self-hosted here is free **Bebas Neue**, the single-weight cut of the same family. Oswald remains the fallback.

THE NAME · CONDENSED

DARREN HARDY

His name only, wherever it is set large: the cover band, a page footer, a signature. It is deliberately not the display face, which is what makes the byline read as a separate voice.

Jacket sets **Franklin Gothic Condensed** (commercial, ITC/Monotype). That cut has no OFL equivalent, so **Archivo Narrow** stands in here, the closest free face in the American-gothic family. The real name is first in the stack, so a licensed machine uses it.

BODY

Inter

Every paragraph, lede, caption, form field, button and piece of fine print. If a person reads more than one line of it, it is Inter.

No	Never ask Bebas for a bold.	The free cut ships one weight, so 500 or 700 makes the browser synthesise a fake bold and smear the letterforms. Weight stays 400 and	emphasis comes from size	, which is how the jacket builds its hierarchy anyway.
-----------	------------------------------------	---	---------------------------------	--

No	Never set a paragraph in Bebas. It is a display face with no lowercase.
-----------	---

No	Never set a headline in Inter or Franklin. Those read as a web app and a byline respectively.
-----------	---

No	Never italicise. The system has no italic: emphasis is the accent colour, which is why	em	is redefined as red rather than slanted.
-----------	--	-----------	--

Yes	Franklin is reserved for his name. Using it elsewhere spends the one thing that makes the byline distinct.
------------	--

Two licences to price before production. What is self-hosted today is free and safe to ship, but it is not what the jacket is set in. **Bebas Neue Pro** adds the Book, Bold and Expanded cuts plus lowercase; if the printed title uses any of those, the site and the book will visibly diverge until a webfont licence is bought. **Franklin Gothic** is the same situation: Libre Franklin is a good revival, but set at cover size next to the real thing the difference shows.

Still open: the body face on the jacket. DH confirmed the title and the name. The flap and back-panel copy is set in a condensed gothic that is plausibly Franklin, not Inter. If it is, there is a case for moving web body copy to Franklin too and running the whole property on two faces instead of three. Worth confirming before the type system is locked.

08 · LICENCE & HOSTING

BUY THE REAL FACES. SELF-HOST BOTH.

DH confirmed the jacket faces. Both are commercial, and what is running on the web pages today is free approximations of them.

Bebas Neue Pro

Display. Titles, lockups, headlines, numbers. **Licence required.** Currently substituted with Bebas Neue (free), which lacks the weights and the lowercase.

Franklin Gothic

The author name only. **Licence required.** Currently substituted with Archivo Narrow.

Body face

Long-form reading. Not yet confirmed against the jacket, and possibly Franklin, which would make this a two-face system rather than three.

Self-host, never a CDN. Both faces are served as woff2 from the property itself via @font-face. No Google Fonts, no third-party font host. That keeps the licence auditable, removes a render-blocking third party, and stops the type changing under the brand if a CDN changes what it serves.

OPEN · BLOCKING

Neither licence is purchased. Until they are, every page is running approximations and the web property does not match the printed jacket. This is the one open item that blocks shipping a site rather than just a document.

09 · THE SCALE

NINE STEPS. USE THESE, NOT NEW ONES.

Every size below is already built into tceb.css. Display sizes are fluid and clamp between a phone minimum and a desktop maximum.

.d1

42 → 96

The page headline. One only.

Oswald 500 caps

0.94

.d2

Oswald 500 caps

32 → 60

0.98

Section headline.

.d3

Oswald 500 caps

23 → 36

1.04

Sub-section, moneyline, pull quote.

.d4

Oswald 500 caps

18 → 23

1.16

Card titles, tier names, labels. Tracking +0.02em.

.eyebrow

Oswald 500 caps

12

—

Section marker above a headline. Tracking wide.

.lede

Inter 400

17 → 20

1.62

The paragraph directly under a headline.

.body

Inter 400

17

1.72

Running copy. Max 66 characters per line.

.small

Inter 400

13.5

1.60

Captions, notes, table cells.

.fine

Inter 400

12

1.55

Legal, disclaimers, unsubscribe. Grey, underline links only.

AT SIZE

.d1

MONTH THIRTY-ONE

.d2

THE OPERATING SYSTEM

.d3

THE PENNY DOUBLES. AN ORG CHART MULTIPLIES.

.d4

THE COMPOUNDING AUDIT

.eyebrow

CHAPTER ONE

.lede

You just did not write it. It is running right now, made of defaults: what happens when nobody decides.

.body

Every strategy, tool, campaign, hire and technology you install sits on top of that system and performs, or fails, according to it.

.small

A dozen leaks of the same size runs \$450,000 a year.

.fine

Year two renews at \$9,995. Cancel any time.

The caps ceiling. Display is always uppercase, and uppercase is capped by word count, not by line count: **eight words maximum, six preferred.** A longer idea splits into a short caps punch plus a sentence-case line beneath it. This is the rule most often broken, because a headline that fits the box can still be four words too long.

10 · COMPOSITION

THE BAND.

The cover's structure is a black field framed by two white bands. That device is the layout system, not just cover art. It gives a page its rhythm without a single extra colour.

FROM THE AUTHOR OF THE COMPOUND EFFECT

2 MILLION + COPIES SOLD

THE COMPOUND EFFECT **IN BUSINESS**

MULTIPLY YOUR PROFITS, YOUR PEOPLE, YOUR ADVANTAGE

DARREN HARDY

THECOMPOUNDEFFECT.COM/**BUSINESS**

How it carries to a page. Black section, white band above and below, the band holding one small line of type. On a web page the bands

become the nav and the footer, and the black field becomes the statement between them. Same device, same proportions.

11 · BUTTONS & THE CTA SYSTEM

ONE PRIMARY PER VIEW.

Two tiers, and they never appear at the same weight in the same screen. The ghost invites. The solid converts.

PRIMARY · SOLID



GET ON THE LIST →

Red fill, white type, 3px radius. One per view, at the point of conversion. On a dark ground the fill stays red; it does not become white.

SECONDARY · GHOST



SEE THE BOOK

Transparent, 1px border, type in the ground's ink. Used in the nav and beside a primary. It may fill on hover; the solid may not.

No **A solid button never darkens on hover.** Colour is held constant. It grows and the arrow travels.

No Pill shapes. 3px radius everywhere. The jacket has no round corners and neither does this.

No Two solids in one view. If a second action is needed it is a ghost or a link.

Yes Ghost may fill on hover, flipping its type to the ground colour.

Yes Placement: ghost in the nav, content between, solid at the close.

Why the hover rule exists. Darkening on hover reads as the button being spent or disabled. Growing and moving the arrow reads as the button responding. The colour is a brand constant and hover is not the place to modulate it.

12 · FORMS & THE GLASS CARD

A LENS, NOT A PANE.

Frosted glass is one layer: blur plus a milky veil. It hides what is behind it and reads flat. The brand's form card is a lens. The body is barely blurred and all the character lives at the rim, where the light bends.

frost

The legibility blur. Always on, and deliberately separate from the refraction so a browser that cannot render the bend still produces a readable form.

refract

The bend itself: a displacement filter masked to the rim only. Refraction belongs in the bevel; the centre of a slab passes light straight through.

lens

A second, harder filter faded inward over the rim. A hard-edged mask here reads as a picture frame.

fringe

Chromatic dispersion, kept under 10% or it stops reading as glass and starts reading as a mistake.

edge

Every bevel and inset highlight. Above the glass, or its own blur softens the 1px lit edge.

spec

A highlight travelling around the rim, driven by an animated conic angle.

The trap that silently kills it. An element with `backdrop-filter`, `isolation:isolate`, or `will-change:transform` becomes a **backdrop root**. A descendant's `backdrop-filter` can then only see what is painted inside that root, which is nothing. The card paints, the glass does not, and there is no error. If the glass is missing, look for a backdrop root above it before looking at the filter.

On a light ground, commit to black. A dark card at 20–30% over a photograph is not glass, it is dirt: the plate shows through as grey and the eyebrow drops to around 3:1. The light version is a solid near-black slab that keeps the rim, the bevel and the specular, and gives up the transparency that was buying nothing.

TWO FOOTERS. PICK DELIBERATELY.

The jacket's device carries straight to the page: a band above, a band below, and the statement between them. The nav is the top band. The footer is the bottom one.

SLIM FOOTER

One line: identity, a legal link, nothing else. **Every action page takes this** — sign-up, sale lead-in, confirmation. A page whose job is one decision does not offer twelve other ways to leave.

FULL FOOTER

Navigation, secondary links, the DH parent mark. **General brand pages only.** If you are unsure which a page is, it is an action page and it takes the slim one.

No Full footer on a confirmation page.

No A solid CTA in the nav. The nav invites; it does not convert.

Yes Nav carries the franchise lockup at small size, and one ghost action, right-aligned.

Yes The footer is where the DH parent mark lives.

THE JACKET IS THE ONLY ASSET.

This property owns two pieces of real imagery: the two jackets. Everything else is borrowed, commissioned, or invented, and the rules differ sharply between those.

No **A testimonial is a banked result.** Already happened, with a magnitude. A projection, a compliment or an event story is not a testimonial, and a bigger number does not rescue a projection.

No Circular avatars. A rectangular portrait beside the quote, in a split layout.

No Cut-outs on a brand-colour field. Real photo on its real background. Colour lives in the card, never behind the head.

No A subject whose body is turned away from the copy. Fix by side or by mirror, and never mirror branded kit.

No Generated imagery of people or places. Retouching a real photograph is fine; generating one is not.

Separating a black book from a dark page. The jacket is the darkest thing in the frame, so it cannot be separated by value. It is separated by **light**: an ambient pool behind it, a rim along the lit edge, and a real contact shadow beneath. That is how black product is photographed and it is the answer to "the jacket is black so the page cannot be".

Give it thickness. A flat image of a cover reads as a picture of a book. A spine, a page edge and a floor read as a book. Where the object is the subject, build it.

MEASURED, NOT ASSUMED.

Every accent against every ground it is allowed on. 4.5:1 carries body text, 3:1 carries large text and UI. Anything below 3 does not carry type at all, whatever it looks like in a swatch.

TCE red on white #E02726 on #FFFFFF	4.68 BODY
TCE ink on white #241F21 on #FFFFFF	16.24 BODY
White on TCE band #FFFFFF on #241F21	16.24 BODY
TCEB red-ink on white #E1132E on #FFFFFF	4.85 BODY
TCEB bright red on black #FF0047 on #000000	5.34 BODY
TCEB red-ink on black #E1132E on #000000	4.33 LARGE ONLY
Gold on black #D4A017 on #000000	8.84 BODY
Gold on white #D4A017 on #FFFFFF	2.38 FAILS
Gold lux on black #CAA76A on #000000	9.25 BODY

Grey 55 on white

#6E6E6E on #FFFFFF

5.10 BODY

Grey 30 on black

#B3B3B3 on #000000

10.02 BODY

The one that catches people. Gold is a dark-ground colour. On white it is 2.38:1 and illegible at any size. If a light ground is in play, the accent is red.

16 · WEB IMPLEMENTATION

THE TOKENS. USE THESE, NOT NEW ONES.

Paste block. Anything that has to sit on the ground must read a token that moves with the ground, never a hardcoded value.

```
:root{
  /* grounds */
  --c-white:#ffffff;    --c-black:#000000;    --c-near:#0e0d10;
  --c-paper:#fbfaf8;    --c-bone:#f0f0f0;    --c-ink:#241f21;

  /* accent. red once per view. gold on dark grounds only. */
  --c-red:#e1132e;      --c-red-bright:#ff0047;
  --c-gold:#d4a017;      --c-gold-lux:#caa76a;

  /* neutrals are type tiers, not grounds */
  --fg:#000;    --fg-soft:#4d4d4d;    --fg-mute:#6e6e6e;    --fg-fine:#b3b3b3;

  /* type */
  --font-display:'Bebas Neue Pro',sans-serif;
  --font-name:'Franklin Gothic Condensed',sans-serif;
```

```
--font-body:system-ui,sans-serif;

/* geometry. 3px everywhere. no pills. */
--radius:3px; --container:1200px; --gutter:clamp(20px,4vw,56px);
}
```

The token trap. A value written as a literal inside a rule that also serves the other theme will be correct on one ground and wrong on the other, and it will not error. Vignettes, scrims, footers and anything inverted are where this happens. If it sits on the ground, it reads a token.

17 · MOTION

RESERVED.

TO BE WRITTEN · HIGH PRIORITY

Motion is deliberately not specified in v1, and it is the most important gap in this document. The vocabulary exists and is in use across the hero studies: the easing curve, scroll-reveal distance, parallax rated by depth rather than applied flat, entrance ordered the way a room is lit, ambient drift so a page is alive before anyone touches it, and prefers-reduced-motion honoured throughout.

It is held back until the hero direction is settled, so the rules describe what was chosen rather than everything that was tried. **This section is written next.**

HOW IT IS WRITTEN.

The type rules and the copy rules are one system. A headline that breaks these will look wrong no matter how it is set.

No **Em dashes.** Ever. Restructure the sentence.

No **"Buy."** They invest. They never purchase.

No Opening on the problem. Lead with the outcome and its emotion. Format, duration and mechanics never lead.

No An all-caps headline over eight words. Six is better. Split a longer idea into a caps punch plus sentence-case detail.

No Naming the paid product on a free or pre-sale page, testimonials included. Trim the quote instead.

No Funnel language anywhere a reader can see it, page names included.

Yes "Leader", not "owner".

Yes After a purchase, affirm the decision first and offer the multiplier second. No loss framing.

Orphans are a type failure, not a copy failure. The display face is set in authored line breaks, not wrapped. A single word alone on a line is the most common way to make this face look cheap. Size the type to the break, do not narrow the measure until the break appears.

WHAT IS NOT SETTLED YET.

BLOCKING

Font licences. Bebas Neue Pro and Franklin Gothic are both unpurchased. Every page currently runs approximations. This blocks shipping a site, not just this document.

NEEDS DH

A drawn wordmark. The lockup is set type. For four sites and any merchandise, a drawn mark is worth commissioning.

NEXT

Motion, section 17. Written once the hero direction is chosen.

UNCONFIRMED

The TCE palette is measured from the 10th Anniversary cover artwork in the repo, not supplied by DH. The colours are sound; the file's proportions may be an ebook mock rather than the real trim.

UNCONFIRMED

The body face. Not yet checked against the jacket. If it is Franklin, this becomes a two-face system.
